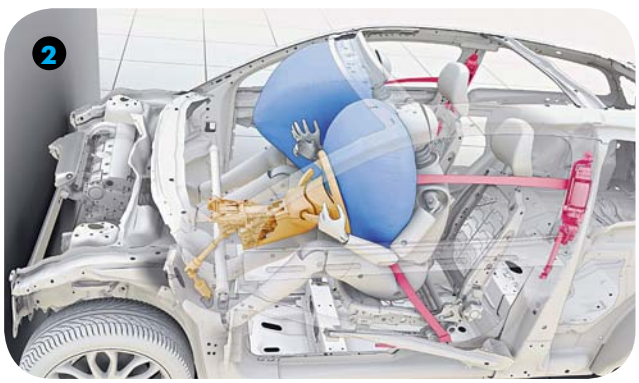




CRASH COURSE

1: Airbags supplement seat belts

2: Seat belts are primary restraint systems

3 &4: Both Mahindra XUV700 & Skoda Kushaq get five-star rating

programmes, each car is rated on a five-star scale for both adult and child safety (in some for pedestrian safety too). Their websites have actual scores that can help you decide between cars with the same star rating. Also worth noting is the equipment levels of the cars tested and if the scale is actually comparable. For example, Global NCAP has just shifted to a more rigorous regime, so earlier ratings are not exactly comparable to those done later this year and in the future. Similarly, ratings of other new car assessment programmes may or may not be applicable to the same models in India.

I have said that airbags are good to have but not essential for safety. That is validated by the fact that some cars get five-star ratings with only two airbags, while others with six have at times got only three stars. There are other more critical safety factors and structural integrity is one. If the car has been assessed, there would be a comment on that on its ratings sheet. Finally, ADAS features lead to roads being safer and active safety systems like ABS and ESP help prevent accidents. It is best to have them as they prevent accidents rather than ensure that you are safe in case of an accident.

But if you have no idea how safe your car is, make sure everyone is wearing seat belts, as that will save lives, reduce the scale of injuries and at times help people walk out of crashed cars unscathed. ■



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